GUJARAT

A SOLUTION FLOWS PAST THE PROBLEM

Ahmedabad's citizens and officials toil hard at cleaning the Sabarmati, but what plagues the river is a deep rot

By **Jumana Shah**



FOR SABARMATI Municipal staff, volunteers do the spade work

IT'S A SEWAGE DRAIN, IT'S A GARBAGE BIN, no, it's a riverbed! The 11.5 km stretch of Sabarmati along the much-feted Riverfront in Ahmedabad has been emptied of water. How and why? The first is easily answered. The Sabarmati doesn't exactly fit the classic prototype of a flowing river, much less a perennial one. Narmada water is diverted into it from a canal 20 km upstream from the Riverfront, and a barrage holds it in at the other end—so it's functionally closer to a long lake under human control. Ergo, it can be emptied.

TONNES OF MUCK

'Why' yields a rather more intriguing answer. In what's possibly an exercise that's never been seen before in the world, an emptied river is being cleaned—manually. Good samaritans and tireless squads of the Ahmedabad Municipal Corporation (AMC) are physically picking up filth from the riverbed. The Sabarmati Riverfront has been projected as an urban marvel, but there's one fact that never made it to tourism brochures.

This hallowed water body, whose very name evokes the self-cleansing ethos of a Mahatma, has entire rivers of untreated sewage flowing into through 43 outfalls within city limits. The AMC estimates the volumes of vile sludge at some 786.49 million litres per day (MLD). Add plastic garbage, discarded clothes and religious flags, and you can see why 251 tonnes of garbage was removed from the riverbed in just the first four days of the month-long drive.

Takeaways

- **Thousands of citizens join in as Sabarmati is emptied for some vigorous manual cleaning of its riverbed**
- **But with 786 million litres of sewage flowing in daily, the issue stays unresolved**

Summer brought the chance for spring cleaning. If the Karai Dam controls the water inflow, the Vasna barrage keeps the water within the city. "One barrage door had to be repaired, so water had to be drained for a month. I turned adversity into opportunity and invited volunteers to help clean the riverbed," says AMC commissioner Bancha Nidhi Pani. "On average, 2,500 volunteers turn up every morning, with the number reaching 10,000 on a Sunday." So it has genuinely resonated